

`Remembering the Great Depression

With the outlook gloomy for the U.S. economy, TIME takes a look back at what it was like during some of the nation's darkest days — through the eyes of those who were there.

*Judith Crist

New York City



I had a very affluent childhood right up until I was about nine. We lived in several gracious homes, I went to private school, we had a live-in servant and so on. My father had a bulletproof Cadillac he had bought from a bootlegger.

I was born in New York City because my parents were American citizens and they wanted their children born there. As I always say, my mother came home to foal. My father was a fur trader, though, so I spent most of my childhood in Canada.

And then suddenly, our most gracious home was gone. The servants left. I was so dumb that when we were losing the last of our grand houses, I told my classmates that "Gee, bailiffs are coming to our house." I didn't know what a bailiff was or what that meant. I was too damn young. After we lost the last of our homes, we moved to New York to get some kind of assistance from my mother's family.

Well, from both of my parents' families. We lived in a small, one-bedroom apartment while my father went out on the road, recouping things. He was a traveling salesman, he always had a new invention. He sold a dry cleaning machine, and a machine for printing things on bags and signs. As I entered my teens, I really felt the blow of the depression.

When I came to New York, I was astounded that not everybody wore fur coats. I was astounded that not every apartment had a dining room. I wore my hair in a kind of Alice in Wonderland style, and one of my teachers told me to tell my mother to braid my hair — so I didn't "pick up things." Lice were not unknown among impoverished families at the time.

I do remember once — my father never quite excused me for saying this — I said to him, "Why don't you become a milk man? Like so-and-so's father, at least he earns \$28 a week!" I must have been about 12 or 13 when I said that brilliant thing to my father.

*Lawrence Brown



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Carmin, Ill.

I was born in 1928 in Carmine, Illinois, where I live now. We raised watermelons and corn and you just couldn't sell anything. Nobody was buying any of our commodities. I remember we loaded them on train cars and sent them to Chicago to the market. And I can remember we sent them up there with the idea that they'd send us some money back. Well, the sellers went broke and didn't send us the money. And then we got a call from the railroad company wanting us to pay the freight [Laughs]. Back in those days, we didn't have anything to speak of — didn't have electricity, didn't have indoor plumbing. We didn't even have a radio. I remember my mother wanting a telephone, and dad didn't think we could afford it. They had a heck of an argument over it.

It was rough, but everybody was in the same boat. Nobody had anything. Every room had a stove then, we didn't have furnaces, you know. And a lot of people didn't have wood and couldn't afford coal. People were actually burning their corn for heat. You couldn't sell it, so might as well do something with it. We came home one night and somebody had broken into our house and stolen all our food. They didn't want money, they just had to have food. We had livestock so we always had meat. We were pretty self-sufficient in that way. The people who were really hurting, I think, were the people who worked in the cities. The people who had jobs at manufacturing plants that went broke. Dad kind of griped about it, said, "All those guys who went off and made a lot of money in Detroit or Chicago or Toledo, now that they lost their jobs, they come back and try to get a job on the farm."

Back then, I was so young, I really didn't know much. I was just 6, 8, 10 years old when the worst hit. But I'm worried to death about the economy now. We've always owned ground and I've invested money and I've really taken a beating in this market like everybody else. When we put in the crop this year — my son does the farming, I'm retired — it cost him a fortune because herbicides and fertilizer and machinery costs are so high. And our commodities — corn, soybean and wheat — have lost half their value.

***Fran Suddath**



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Jackson, Miss.

My daddy's company went broke, they went bust on everything. His job was taken away, so we moved in with my grandmother in another town. I was young, maybe six years old, so for me, my life went on and I went to school. My daddy tried to find work, but he was an accountant and it was a very difficult time for accountants back then. He lost his job in 1930, and was out of work for 5 or 6 years. He would get up and go downtown every day to see if there was anything available. There usually wasn't.

When I was in senior high school, I had one wool skirt in the wintertime and two blouses that went with it. I would wear one blouse and wash the other one out in the sink so I could wear it the next day. One girl in our high school, she just had the most wonderful clothes. Everything she had was marvelous. But her daddy owned the newspaper, they had money. The rest of us, we went on with our activities — our dating and dancing —everybody was in the same fix. It was hard.

My mother never went to work. At that time, the only jobs available for women in the workforce were as cooks or janitors or something like that and my mamma wasn't going to do something like that. It wasn't a good era for women to be working. She never worked.

We had no savings. We went through that real fast in the beginning. My daddy took any job he could find, even manual labor, he would take it. The thing about it was that my mother and daddy were so wonderful, they never talked about money or the lack of it in front of my sister and me. They did all that privately. It wasn't until after I was grown and married that I realized how horrible it must have been. But they never let on about it. We just knew that we couldn't have things, and that was it.

*Ernestine McMillan Hilton

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Cheney, WA



My family consisted of my mother and father, my two younger brothers and my younger sister. My mother's baby sister came to live with us. My father's brother lived with us from time to time. Everybody did it in those days. Children had to go stay with grandparents and aunts and uncles simply because their parents couldn't afford to feed them and clothe them. The teachers weren't being paid because people weren't paying their taxes.

We lived in a three-room house, just a little country shack. My father had this dream to move up of course, so he had rented this bigger 8-room house. We all loved the house, so it was quite a blow to give that up. We went back to the little house. And then we were squatting on a place down the road.

I remember my father and grandparents trying so hard to save our ranch. The bank failed and new [managers] came in. They didn't know anything about farming and they wouldn't loan money. Our cattle were auctioned off by the bank. At the auction, some of our neighbors bought my pony and gave it back to us. They saved a cow for us that way. My mother would take her crate of eggs into the stores and she would bargain with them and that's how we got our food and our clothing.

I remember the morning grandmother went to her linen closet and took out a cigar box where she kept her chicken money. She counted it and parceled it out to my father and his brother and kept some for herself just to have grocery money. My family were stoic Scots. You didn't see them cry and carry on. But I remember so vividly when we got ready to go home, grandma just tousled my hair and said, "Thank you for coming with your daddy. This has been a hard day."